CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Friday, November 6, 2026

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RE: Fiji ratifies Australia defence treaty · NZ votes Saturday, too close to call · USS Colorado docks at HMAS Stirling · Vanuatu no-confidence vote Monday · Midterms reshape Canberra's AUKUS calculus

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
9,021	0.6871	13,998	0.5545
+1.27%	-2.25%	+1.46%	-1.42%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · AUKUS · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Fiji's parliament passed its mutual defence treaty with Australia under the Ocean of Peace Alliance, overriding opposition objections that binding commitments cut against Fijian sovereignty.
2. New Zealanders vote Saturday in a contest Reuters calls too close to call, with Opportunity leader Qiulae Wong positioned as a possible kingmaker alongside the two Chrises.
3. Canberra is recalibrating AUKUS, data centre and China policy after Democrats won both chambers of Congress, with cabinet ministers and diplomats watching the midterm result closely, Guardian Australia reports.

TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Fiji's parliament approves mutual defence treaty with Australia

Parliament approved Fiji's mutual defence treaty with Australia under the Ocean of Peace Alliance despite opposition concerns over sovereignty and an independent foreign policy. Opposition MP **Virendra Lal** asked why Fiji was accepting binding mutual defence commitments when Australia's security agreement with Ukraine carries no equivalent obligations.

per FBC News (Fiji): "Parliament clears Australia treaties"

NZ-POLITICS

New Zealand's campaign ends with the result too close to call

Reuters reports the New Zealand campaign entering its final day with the outcome unresolved before Saturday's vote. The Sydney Morning Herald reports the contest is dominated by the cost of living and **Qiulae Wong**, the Opportunity leader who answered a job advertisement to lead the party last year and is now in contention as kingmaker against the two Chrises, Christopher Luxon and Chris Hipkins.

per Reuters: "New Zealand election campaign enters final day with result too close to call - Reuters" · also Sydney Morning Herald

US-AUSTRALIA

Canberra reads the midterms for AUKUS, data centres and China

Cabinet ministers, diplomats and the defence industrial sector watched control of Congress flip to the Democrats this week, with analysts telling the Guardian the result reshapes the outlook for AUKUS, data centre development and relations with China over **Donald Trump**'s final two years. The same report says **Anthony Albanese**'s government has taken a blow from the Iran war, while cost-of-living anxiety and data centres may hit harder at home.

per Guardian Australia (Tom McIlroy): "Australia faces same issues that flipped control of US Congress in midterms, experts say"

OVERNIGHT

US-AUSTRALIA

PM to lobby Trump over Iran, tariffs · The Australian

The Australian reports the prime minister intends to lobby the US president over Iran and tariffs. The move follows a week in which the government attributed domestic inflation partly to the oil shock from the Middle East conflict.

TRADE-ECONOMY

US voters put data centers on notice, Australia could be next · Politico

Politico reports American voters turning against data centre development and flags Australia as the next jurisdiction where the issue could bite. The Reserve Bank this week named data centres among the inflationary pressures behind its latest rate rise, according to Guardian Australia.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Major Australian gas project enters administration as costs soar · Bloomberg

Bloomberg reports a major Australian gas project has entered administration amid soaring costs. The failure lands as energy ministers weigh strategic reserve arrangements against renewable energy shortfalls.

AU-POLITICS

Bondi beach attack victim Eva Geller dies, nearly a year on · Guardian Australia

Eva Geller, 90, who was shot during the Bondi beach attack on December 14, 2025, died in hospital after developing an infection and suffering a stroke. Fifteen people were killed in that attack, which prompted sweeping gun law reforms and a hate speech crackdown; **Naveed Akram** faces 15 counts of murder and 40 of attempted murder.

STAT OF THE DAY

484

average daily abusive comments sent to New Zealand election candidates

Areto Labs analysed abuse directed at 34 candidates over three months to polling day, underscoring the hostility shadowing Saturday's too-close-to-call vote.

Newsroom NZ

AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 1 · DVIDS

USS Colorado arrives at HMAS Stirling for a maintenance period

The US Defense Visual Information Distribution Service recorded USS Colorado (SSN 788) arriving at HMAS Stirling for a submarine maintenance period supporting AUKUS. Colorado was named the first boat of Submarine Rotational Force-West on October 28, 2026.

PILLAR 1 · THE AUSTRALIAN

ALP 'blind' to submarines gap US saw coming

The Australian reports the government failed to anticipate a capability gap in the submarine programme that US planners had flagged. The paper frames this as its own reporting rather than attributing the claim to a named official.

PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · RNZ PACIFIC

Fiji minister says she will lose her Cabinet job either way on constitution vote

Fiji's Minister for Women, Children and Social Protection, **Sashi Kiran**, said she will lose her Cabinet position whichever way she votes on the Constitution (Amendment) Bill, which passed its second reading on October 2. Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** has delayed the bill's third reading by at least a month after coalition partners NFP and SODELPA came out against it.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Marape challenges O'Neill to public debate on economic management

PNG Prime Minister **James Marape** challenged former prime minister **Peter O'Neill** to a public debate at the University of Papua New Guinea comparing their respective records over six-year terms in office, as political jockeying ahead of the next electoral cycle intensifies.

VANUATU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Vanuatu Parliament to debate no-confidence motion Monday

Islands Business' PACNEWS wire reports Vanuatu's Parliament will debate a no-confidence motion on Monday, as the government separately moves to appeal a court ruling requiring a referendum for constitutional changes.

REGIONAL · RNZ PACIFIC

Pacific states warn of debt pressure as Commonwealth vows climate finance action

The 2026 CHOGM communique from St John's, Antigua and Barbuda, recognised growing climate finance challenges facing small island developing states. Samoa's deputy prime minister **Mulipola Anarosa Ale**

Molio'o warned Pacific countries should not be forced into debt to recover from climate disasters they did little to cause, and Fiji's special envoy **Ratu Inoke Kubuabola** pressed for grant-based finance.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu prepares first powdered ginger export shipment

The Vanuatu Bureau of Standards confirmed the country is preparing its first powdered ginger export, with a 20-foot container of roughly *15 tonnes* expected to generate around VT9 million at the pack-house level, following an earlier standards cooperation agreement with Standards Australia.

FIJI · FIJIVILLAGE

Fiji Police Force Bill passed, broadening arrest and search powers

Fiji's Parliament unanimously passed the Police Force Bill, which permits arrest without warrant and proportionate use of force, and establishes a statutory framework for community policing. Minister for Policing **Ioane Naivalurua** called it 'a fundamental modernisation' of Fiji's policing framework.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ POLITICAL

New Zealand heads into its most unpredictable election night in the MMP era

New Zealand's Saturday election could return more than 120 seats to Parliament, RNZ reports, as overhangs from Te Pati Maori and National push the chamber past its usual size. National's party vote is likely to fall from its current 49 seats to somewhere between 25 and 32 percent, with electorate results and special votes able to shift the final outcome.

NZ-POLITICS · NEWSROOM NZ

New Zealand candidates faced 484 abusive comments a day, data shows

New Zealand election candidates received an average of *484* abusive comments a day over three months to polling day, according to AI moderation firm Areto Labs' analysis of 34 candidates' social media accounts. Opportunity leader **Qiulae Wong** said misogynistic abuse directed at her female candidates, including comments from NZ First's Michael Laws, had made her 'skin crawl.'

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Productivity Commission chair warns on Labor's workplace reforms

Australia's Productivity Commission chair said Labor's workplace reforms should be examined for their role in the country's economic malaise, SMH's **Paul Sakkal** reports, a rare public rebuke of the government's industrial relations agenda from its own statutory adviser.

AU-POLITICS · AFR

Chalmers' gag on Productivity Commission beyond a joke, say Libs

The Australian Financial Review reports the Coalition accusing Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** of muzzling the Productivity Commission, intensifying pressure on the government's economic credibility ahead of a mid-December budget update.

AU-POLITICS · GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

One Nation asks Sydney fundraiser donors to sign NDAs

One Nation is asking donors at a $3,000-a-head Sydney fundraiser featuring **Pauline Hanson** to accept non-disclosure agreements, Guardian Australia reports, a move transparency experts called a worrying precedent

ahead of the New South Wales election.

AU-POLITICS · GUARDIAN AU POLITICS

Woman charged with stalking Greens senator Steele-John granted bail

A Perth court granted bail to a 40-year-old woman charged with stalking and attempting to extort Greens senator **Jordon Steele-John**, ordering her to surrender her passport within 48 hours and stay 100 metres from him, his home and his workplace.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Macquarie sees Australia gaining from US data center woes

Bloomberg reports Macquarie sees Australia positioned to benefit as US data centre development runs into political resistance, a shift Politico separately links to American voters' backlash against the sector in this week's midterms.

TRADE-ECONOMY · GUARDIAN AU POLITICS

AI and data centres could be political kryptonite in Australia

Guardian Australia's **Josh Butler** writes that Australians have yet to see tangible benefits from the AI and data centre boom, with the Reserve Bank naming data centres among the inflationary pressures behind this week's rate rise. The piece warns the sector could turn politically toxic as it did in the US midterms.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · POST COURIER

Pacific Islands Forum chair leads mission to strengthen PIF-UAE cooperation

A Pacific Islands Forum delegation led by the chair conducted an outreach mission aimed at strengthening cooperation between the Forum and the United Arab Emirates, part of continuing engagement with non-traditional development partners.

UPCOMING

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Advance voting closed and the race is too close to call, with Opportunity leader Qiulae Wong a potential kingmaker between National and NZ First.

NOV 9

Vanuatu Parliament debates a no-confidence motion

A successful motion would add to political instability as the government also appeals a court ruling on referendum requirements for constitutional change.

NOV 9

COP31 opens in Antalya

Australia is leading negotiations with Pacific priorities at the centre, and Prime Minister Albanese has delayed his departure to chair budget meetings first.

DEC
2026

Fiji's Constitution Amendment Bill returns for a third reading

Prime Minister Rabuka has threatened to expel Cabinet ministers from NFP and SODELPA who vote against the bill, which could fracture the governing coalition.

THE WIRE

TRADE-ECONOMY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Varroa and Fiji's beekeepers: acting before the next incursion

A Fiji-based beekeeper from Rakiraki writes that varroa destructor, which reached Australia in 2022, is one boat ride from Fiji, and that thin surveillance and no hive-loss reporting system leave the sector exposed. The piece sets out four low-cost steps to prepare before the mite arrives.

AUKUS

ASPI STRATEGIST

China doesn't need to dominate the world to threaten Australia's security

ASPI's Strategist rebuts former defence force chief **Chris Barrie**'s argument, made while presenting the crowd-funded AUKUS inquiry's findings, that China shows no evidence of global dominance aspirations comparable to the United States. The piece calls that comparison a false equivalence.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

ASPI STRATEGIST

COP31 should draw on Taiwan's Pacific climate experience

ASPI argues Australia should keep Pacific priorities central at COP31 in Antalya and reaffirm support for Taiwan's participation in climate cooperation, citing the Taku Pakasoa Declaration adopted at the Pacific Pre-COP meeting in Fiji and Tuvalu.

US-CHINA-PACIFIC

ASPI STRATEGIST

After the midterms, the Indo-Pacific awaits one of four different Washingtons

ASPI sets out four scenarios for US Indo-Pacific policy depending on whether a lame-duck president seeks a deal with Beijing or a fight, and whether Democratic hawks or restrainers win the caucus argument over China and funding Indo-Pacific security.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

NEWSROOM NZ

The legacy of Bougainville's self-proclaimed King Musingku

RNZ Pacific's **Johnny Blades** examines the legacy of Noah Musingku, the self-proclaimed King of Papaala who died last month in Bougainville and ran the U-Vistract finance scheme that cost many Pacific investors their savings.

Washington, D.C.

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